Immersed in Uncertainty

The booming Ganesh idol industry in Mumbai's hinterland faces an ecological pushback over the use of polluting PoP. A high court ruling has come as a reprieve, for now

By **DHAVAL S. KULKARNI** *in Pen, Raigad*

In **a small workshop in Hamrapur village, 60 kilometres from Mumbai,** Nitesh Daur stands quietly amid neat rows of white Ganesh idols. Crafted from Plaster of Paris (PoP)—a lightweight, detail-friendly material—the statues have been his livelihood since 2005. "If I shut down this business, what will I do?" asks the 35-year-old father of two. "I have no other skills."

Daur's anxiety stems from a long-running legal battle over the environmental impact of PoP idols, the genesis of which can be traced to a 2005 PIL by the late rationalist Narendra Dabholkar's Maharashtra Andhashraddha Nirmoolan Samiti. On January 30, this year, the Bombay High Court issued an interim order, directing civic bodies across Maharashtra to enforce the Central Pollution Control Board's (CPCB) 2020 guidelines banning the immersion of PoP idols—even in artificial tanks—during the Maghi Ganeshotsav (January-February).

The rationale: PoP's adverse effects on aquatic ecosystems. The result: a swift crackdown by municipal bodies and police. On June 9, the court modified its order, allowing the manufacture and sale of PoP idols—so long as they aren't immersed in natural water bodies. A CPCB expert panel has also clarified that its 2020 guidelines were advisory, not mandatory. The partial reprieve has given idol-makers like Daur some breathing room ahead of this year's main Ganeshotsav, which begins in late August and is the most popular festival in Maharashtra. Then, on July 24, came further clarity. The court ruled that PoP idols under 6 feet in height must be immersed only in artificial water tanks, while taller idols may go into natural water bodies.

The court also directed the state government to ensure local bodies strictly implement these amended norms and to provide enough artificial tanks for immersions. Additionally, the state was told to form an Expert Scientific Committee within a month to explore ways to recycle and reuse PoP and examine eco-friendly methods for faster dissolution. These directions will remain in force for all immersion-based festivals till March 2026. Accordingly, the state government has issued comprehensive guidelines for the immersion of PoP idols.

Even so, not everyone is mollified. Naresh Dahibavkar, president of the Brihanmumbai Sarvajanik Ganeshotsav Samanvay Samiti, welcomes the relief but warns of uncertainty ahead. "This is only an interim order," he says. "Next year, the issue will be back in court." He wants a "permanent solution" to the issue of immersion of large idols—installed by more than 3,000 Ganesh mandals in Mumbai alone. Environmentalist Harshad Dhage, a petitioner in the case, too notes the "temporary" nature of the reprieve. Emphasising the need to strike a balance between faith and sustainability, he says, "This is not a fight against festivals, but against pollution."



GOD IN THE DETAIL
An artisan gives final touches to a Ganesh idol at a workshop in Pen